NZICA WELLNESS RETREAT 2026 · STUDY PAPER · RET-001

Yajña: The Spirit of Seva

Growing through giving, for oneself and for the good of many

A study for members of the New Zealand Indian Central Association, to read before and after the retreat *The Art of Giving: Harmonising Heart, Head and Hands*, Vedanta Retreat Centre, Glen Murray, Sunday 15 November 2026, in person and on Zoom.

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Online version with slides and quiz: ramakrishna-vedanta-centre-nz.github.io/satsangs/RET-001/article/

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How to use this study

This study is a companion to the talk *Yajña: The Spirit of Seva*, given at the NZICA Wellness Retreat, *The Art of Giving: Harmonising Heart, Head and Hands*, at the Vedanta Retreat Centre, Glen Murray. It is written for members of the New Zealand Indian Central Association and their families, and for anyone who wishes to serve with a full heart.

Our spiritual tradition describes three stages of learning. **Śravaṇa** is hearing the teaching with attention: the talk and the slides on the day. **Manana** is reflecting on it, questioning it and making it our own: this paper, read slowly before and after the retreat. **Nididhyāsana** is living it until it becomes part of us: the practices at the end of each section and in Section 11.

Each section ends with a few questions for reflection. You may read one section a day, keep a notebook, or discuss a section in your branch. The Gītā verses quoted are given in full, with Sanskrit, transliteration and meaning, in Appendix B. The renderings of the verses are plain English versions made for this study; for a full translation with Śaṅkara's commentary, see Swami Gambhirananda's *Bhagavad Gītā* (Advaita Ashrama).

1 Why we serve

When NZICA invited Swami Tadananda to speak at this retreat, the Association suggested two themes: the **spirit of seva**, and **what a day looks like in the life of a person dedicated to service**. This study answers both with one ancient idea from the Bhagavad Gītā: **yajña**.

Ask members why they joined NZICA, and most will give two answers. Some joined to **grow**: to learn, to belong, to find meaning. Others joined to **serve**: to help families, elders, newcomers and the wider community of Aotearoa. Most of us joined for both. The motto Swami Vivekananda gave to the Ramakrishna Order joins the two in a single line: *ātmano mokṣārthaṁ jagad-hitāya ca*, "for one's own liberation and for the welfare of the world."

The idea of yajña shows why these are not two paths but one. When we offer our work for the good of others, that very offering purifies our mind and heart. Service becomes our growth; growth makes us better able to serve.

REFLECT

- Why did I join NZICA? Which of the two reasons is stronger in me today?
- When has serving others also changed me?

2 What is yajña?

The word *yajña* comes from the Sanskrit root *yaj*. The classical list of Sanskrit roots gives it three meanings: **worship** (*deva-pūjā*), **coming together** (*saṅgati-karaṇa*) and **giving** (*dāna*). All three belong to the spirit of seva. When we give, we worship; when we come together to give, we form a living community. An association such as NZICA is, in this sense, a yajña in itself.

In Vedic times, yajña meant the fire ritual. Offerings of ghee and grain were poured into the sacred fire with mantras, for the good of the family, the community and the world, and what remained was shared as blessed food. The Bhagavad Gītā keeps this picture but widens it. In the Gītā, Sri Krishna teaches that **any action offered without selfishness, for the good of all and as worship of the Divine, is yajña**. The fire may be the kitchen stove, the office desk, the hospital ward or the community hall. The offering may be our time, our skills, our wealth, our knowledge or simply our care.

> **In one sentence:** yajña is life lived as an offering. Instead of asking "What do I get?", we ask "What can I offer?"

REFLECT

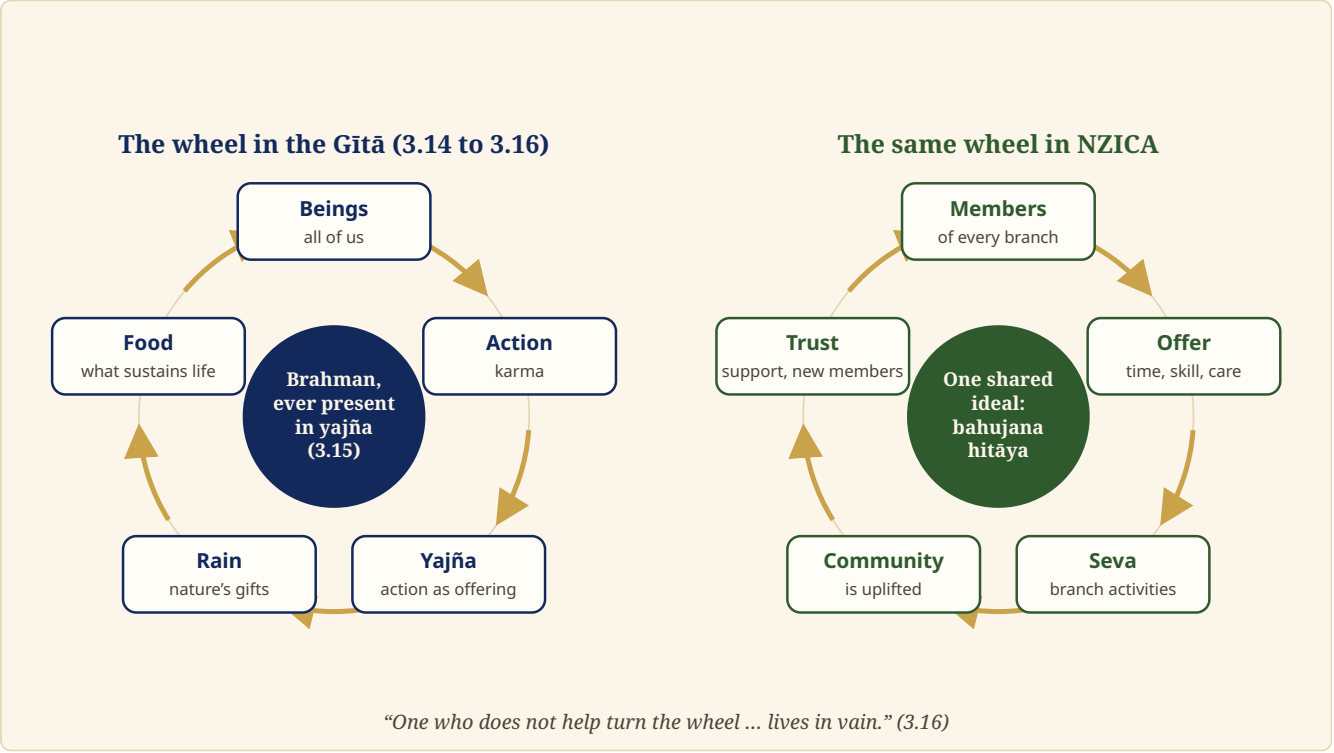
- Which of the three meanings, worship, coming together or giving, do I already practise? Which is missing?

3 The wheel of giving and receiving

UNDERSTANDING

In the third chapter of the Gītā, Sri Krishna describes the whole of life as a wheel. The Creator brought forth beings *together with* yajña, saying, "By this you shall prosper" (3.10). Beings live on food; food comes from rain; rain comes from yajña; and yajña is born of action (3.14). The all-pervading Brahman is ever present in yajña (3.15). In other words, giving is not something added to life from outside. It is built into the way life works.

Look at nature. The sun gives light and asks nothing back. The clouds give rain, the earth gives food, the trees give shade and fruit. Every living being lives on what others give, and in turn gives something back. Verse 3.11 describes this as mutual nourishment: "Nourishing one another, you will attain the highest good." The devas, the divine powers behind nature, give; we receive; we give back; and the wheel turns.



The wheel of yajña in the Gītā, and the same wheel turning in a community association.

Two verses carry a strong practical message. Verse 3.12 says that one who enjoys the gifts of life without offering anything in return "is nothing but a thief". The strong word is meant to wake us up, not to make us feel guilty. A thief takes what is not his; one who takes without giving back is treating as his own what really came from others. Verse 3.13 says that the good, who eat what remains after offering (*yajña-śiṣṭa*), are freed from all faults, while those who cook only for themselves "eat sin". And 3.16 concludes: one who does not help turn the wheel, living only for the senses, "lives in vain".

The heart of this teaching is **gratitude**. Each of us has received far more than we can count: life itself from our parents, knowledge from our teachers, food from the land and its farmers, safety and opportunity from the society of Aotearoa, and a welcoming community from those who came before us and built it. Giving back is not charity. It is our share in turning the wheel.

APPLICATION

- **In the family:** before eating, pause to offer the food in thought or with a short prayer; cook with love for others; enjoy what remains as *prasāda*, blessed food. Thank parents and elders, in words and in care.
- **At work:** remember that your skills were given to you by teachers and mentors. Pass them on: guide a junior colleague, share what you know freely.
- **In NZICA and the branch:** the same wheel turns. Members offer time, skill and care; branch activities serve the community; the community is uplifted; trust and support grow; new members join and give in their turn. Ask: am I helping to turn the wheel, or only riding on it?
- **A simple practice:** once a week, write down five things you received without paying for them, and one thing you will give back.

REFLECTION AND SELF-EVALUATION

REFLECT

- List five things I received this week without paying for them. What could I give back?
- Where am I only taking, at home, at work or in the community?

Self-check: how true is this of me?	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
I pause to be grateful before I eat or enjoy something.			
I give back to the community that supports me.			
I share my skills and knowledge freely with others.			
In my branch I help to turn the wheel rather than only receive.			

Repeat the self-check after thirty days of practice. Growth shows as a move to the right.

4 How yajña purifies: growing through giving

UNDERSTANDING

Sri Krishna says: "This world is bound by work, except work done as yajña. So do your work for that purpose, free from attachment" (3.9). Work done only for ourselves, for name, gain or comfort, ties us more tightly to "I and mine". The same work done as an offering loosens that knot. For one who works in this spirit, "all action melts away completely" (4.23): it leaves no residue of pride, anxiety or resentment.

This is the secret of personal growth through service. Our spiritual tradition calls it **citta-śuddhi**, the purification of the mind. The mind is like a window. When it is covered with the dust of selfish desires, the light within cannot shine through. Every act of unselfish service wipes away a little of that dust. Swami Vivekananda put it boldly in *Karma-Yoga*:

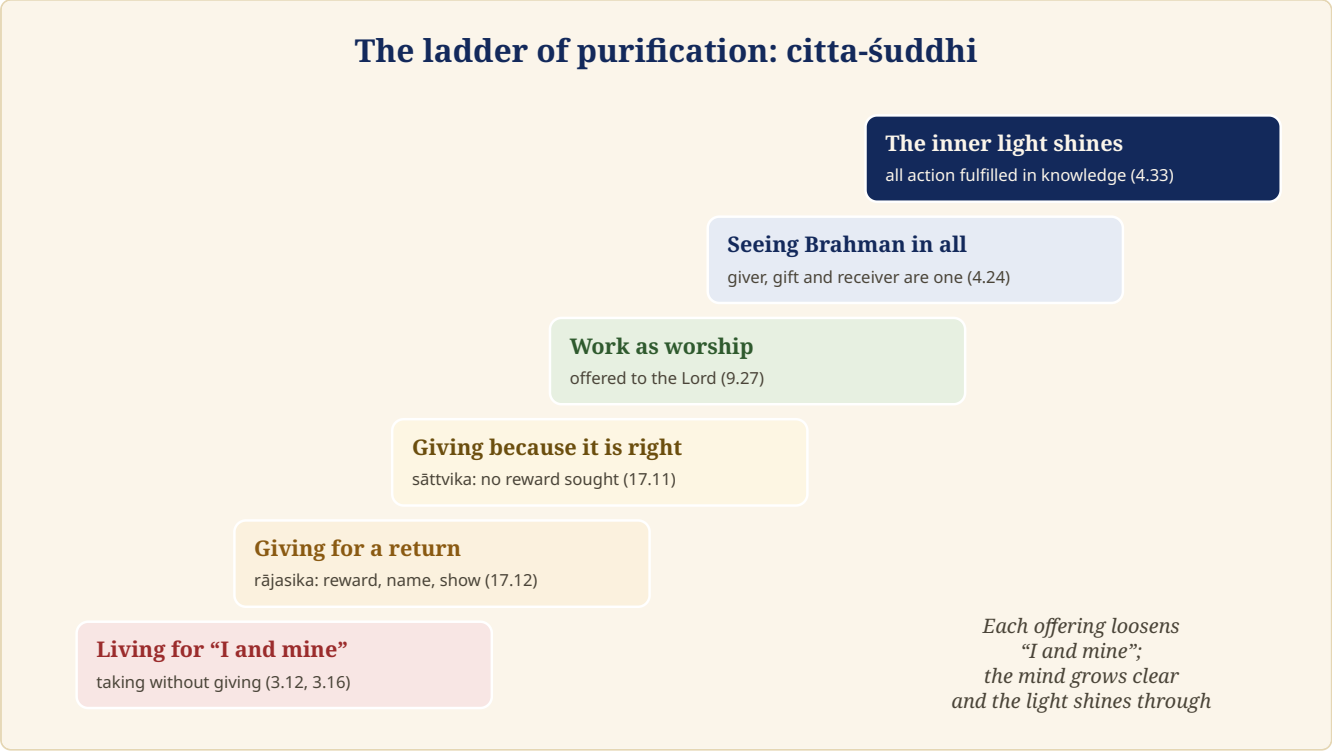
> *"The world is a grand moral gymnasium wherein we have all to take exercise so as to become stronger and stronger spiritually."*
>
> Swami Vivekananda, Karma-Yoga, "We Help Ourselves, Not the World" (Complete Works, Vol. 1)

In the same chapter he turns our usual thinking upside down. We think the giver does a favour to the receiver. He says the opposite:

> *"It is not the receiver that is blessed, but it is the giver."*
>
> *"Is it not a great privilege to be allowed to worship God by helping our fellow-man?"*
>
> Swami Vivekananda, Karma-Yoga (Complete Works, Vol. 1)

Swami Ranganathananda, the thirteenth President of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission, gave a simple test of this growth:

> *"Are you growing spiritually? Can you feel oneness with others? Have you peace within yourself? And do you radiate it around you? That is called spiritual growth, which is stimulated by meditation inwardly, and by work done in a spirit of service outwardly."*
>
> Swami Ranganathananda, 13th President of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission



Each step up the ladder loosens "I and mine", until the light within shines through.

The Gītā describes this rising path in many places. At the bottom is living for "I and mine", taking without giving (3.12). Then comes giving with an eye on the return: reward, recognition or show (17.12). Then giving because it is right, seeking nothing (17.11). Then all work offered to the Lord (9.27). Then seeing Brahman in every part of the offering (4.24). At the top, "all action, without exception, finds its fulfilment in knowledge" (4.33). Sri Krishna adds that yajña, giving and austerity "are not to be given up; they purify even the wise" (18.5). However far we have come, service keeps the heart clean.

APPLICATION

- **Notice the motive.** Before agreeing to help, ask quietly: why am I doing this? For thanks, for a title, or because it ought to be done? There is no need for guilt; simply noticing begins to purify the motive.
- **Let go of the result.** Do the work as well as you can, then let it go. If an event is less successful than hoped, or no one says thank you, offer that too.
- **Be grateful to those you serve.** When helping someone, silently thank them for the chance to grow.
- **Join meditation and service.** A few minutes of meditation each morning gives the strength and purity for service; service tests and deepens the meditation.
- **In the branch:** when someone else takes the credit for shared work, treat it as a step up the ladder rather than a cause for hurt.

REFLECTION AND SELF-EVALUATION

REFLECT

- On which step of the ladder do I usually stand when I serve? What would lift me one step higher?
- Can I recall a time when serving someone made me calmer, kinder or less self-centred?
- Using Swami Ranganathananda's four questions: am I growing spiritually?

Self-check: how true is this of me?	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
I serve without needing thanks or recognition.			
When a result disappoints me, I let it go and carry on.			
I feel grateful to the people I serve.			
I feel more peace and oneness with others than I did a year ago.			

Repeat the self-check after thirty days of practice. Growth shows as a move to the right.

5 The Divine in every part of the offering

UNDERSTANDING

One verse of the Gītā is chanted before meals in many homes and in the ashrams of the Ramakrishna Order:

> ब्रह्मार्पणं ब्रह्म हविर्ब्रह्माग्नौ ब्रह्मणा हुतम् ।
> ब्रह्मैव तेन गन्तव्यं ब्रह्मकर्मसमाधिना ॥
>
> *brahmārpaṇaṁ brahma havir brahmāgnau brahmaṇā hutam,*
> *brahmaiva tena gantavyaṁ brahma-karma-samādhinā*
>
> The act of offering is Brahman, the offering is Brahman, it is offered by Brahman into the fire that is Brahman. One who sees Brahman in every action reaches Brahman alone. (4.24)

In a fire ritual there are five parts: the act of offering, the offering itself, the fire, the one who offers, and the goal. The verse says all five are Brahman, the one infinite Reality. Applied to seva: the one who serves, the service, the person served and the purpose are all the one Divine, appearing in different forms.

This rests on the two pillars of Vedanta. The first is the **divinity of the soul**: as Swami Vivekananda taught, "Each soul is potentially divine" (Raja-Yoga, Complete Works, Vol. 1). The divinity is already there in every person, only covered. The second is the **oneness of existence**: "One who sees all beings in the Self, and the Self in all beings, hates none" (Īśa Upaniṣad 6).

A simple picture helps. We are all like waves on one ocean. Each wave has a different shape, size and story; some are tall, some small, some rising, some breaking on the shore. Yet every wave is made of the same water. The small wave who thinks "I am only this little wave" feels limited, anxious and alone. The wave who knows "I am the ocean" feels its infinite existence, knowledge and bliss: *sat-cit-ānanda*. When we serve, the giver, the gift and the one who receives are waves of the same ocean. In serving others, we serve our own universal Self, the Paramātman.

This is why Swami Vivekananda called service the highest worship. Speaking at the great temple of Rameswaram in 1897, he said:

> *"He who sees Shiva in the poor, in the weak, and in the diseased, really worships Shiva; and if he sees Shiva only in the image, his worship is but preliminary."*
>
> *"He who wants to serve the father must serve the children first."*
>
> Swami Vivekananda, Address at the Rameswaram Temple on Real Worship (Lectures from Colombo to Almora, Complete Works, Vol. 3)

He did not belittle the worship of images; he called it a beginning. Its fulfilment is to see the same Divine living, and often suffering, in human beings, and to serve them. Seva done in this spirit is not charity from above. It is worship of the living God, and it is the discovery of our own larger Self.

APPLICATION

- **Before meals:** chant 4.24, or simply remember that the food, the cook and the one who eats are all the one Divine.
- **Before serving:** pause for a moment and remember, "I am about to worship the Divine in this person." Then speak and act accordingly: with respect, never with pity or superiority.
- **With difficult people:** the same ocean is behind the wave that annoys us. Seeing this does not mean agreeing with everything; it means never losing respect.
- **In the branch:** treat every member, volunteer and guest, from the President to the newest member, as an embodiment of the Divine. Then hierarchy serves, and does not divide.

REFLECTION AND SELF-EVALUATION

REFLECT

- If I truly saw the person I serve as divine, what would change in how I speak to them?
- Try chanting 4.24 before every meal for one week. What do I notice?

Self-check: how true is this of me?	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
I treat the people I serve with respect, never with pity or superiority.			
I remember the Divine in others, especially those I find difficult.			
I offer my food and my work before I begin.			
I feel that in serving others I am serving my own larger Self.			

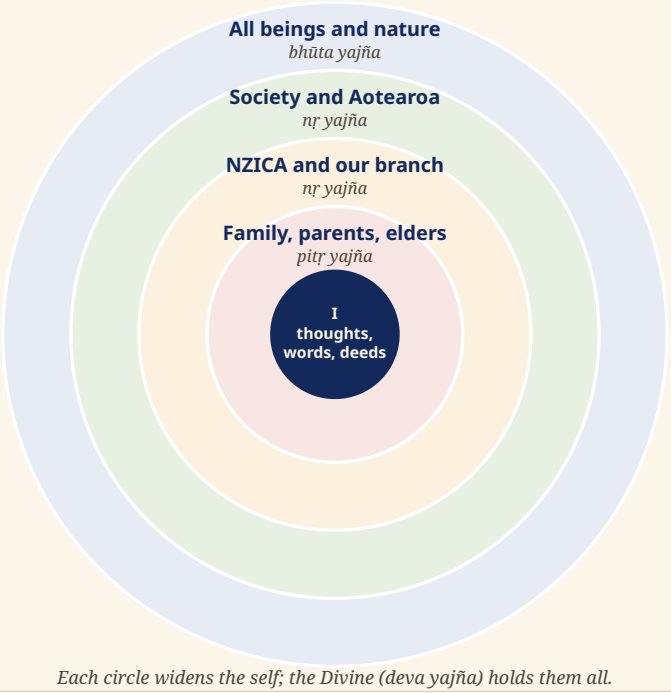
Repeat the self-check after thirty days of practice. Growth shows as a move to the right.

6 Many forms of yajña

In the fourth chapter (4.25 to 4.30), Sri Krishna lists many kinds of yajña. Some offer their wealth (*dravya-yajña*); some their self-discipline (*tapo-yajña*); some their practice of yoga; some study of scripture and knowledge (*svādhyāya* and *jñāna-yajña*); some control of the breath; some restraint of the senses. "All of these know yajña, and through yajña their impurities are destroyed" (4.30). And then: "The yajña of knowledge is higher than any yajña of material things" (4.33). Among all yajñas, Sri Krishna says, "I am japa", the repetition of the holy name (10.25), the simplest offering of all, which anyone can make anywhere.

Swami Vivekananda, in *Karma-Yoga*, speaks of three kinds of help we can give: physical help, such as food and shelter; intellectual help, the gift of knowledge, which he called "a far higher gift than that of food and clothes"; and spiritual help, which he called "the highest help that can be given".

Our spiritual tradition also gives every householder **five daily offerings**, the *pañca mahāyajña*. They widen our circle of care step by step, from the self outwards to all beings.



The five daily offerings

pañca mahāyajña of our spiritual tradition

- ***deva yajña*** — to the Divine: prayer, worship, offering the day
- ***ṛṣi yajña*** — to the sages: daily study of scripture
- ***pitṛ yajña*** — to parents and ancestors: care and gratitude
- ***nṛ yajña*** — to fellow human beings: service and hospitality
- ***bhūta yajña*** — to animals and nature: feeding, protecting

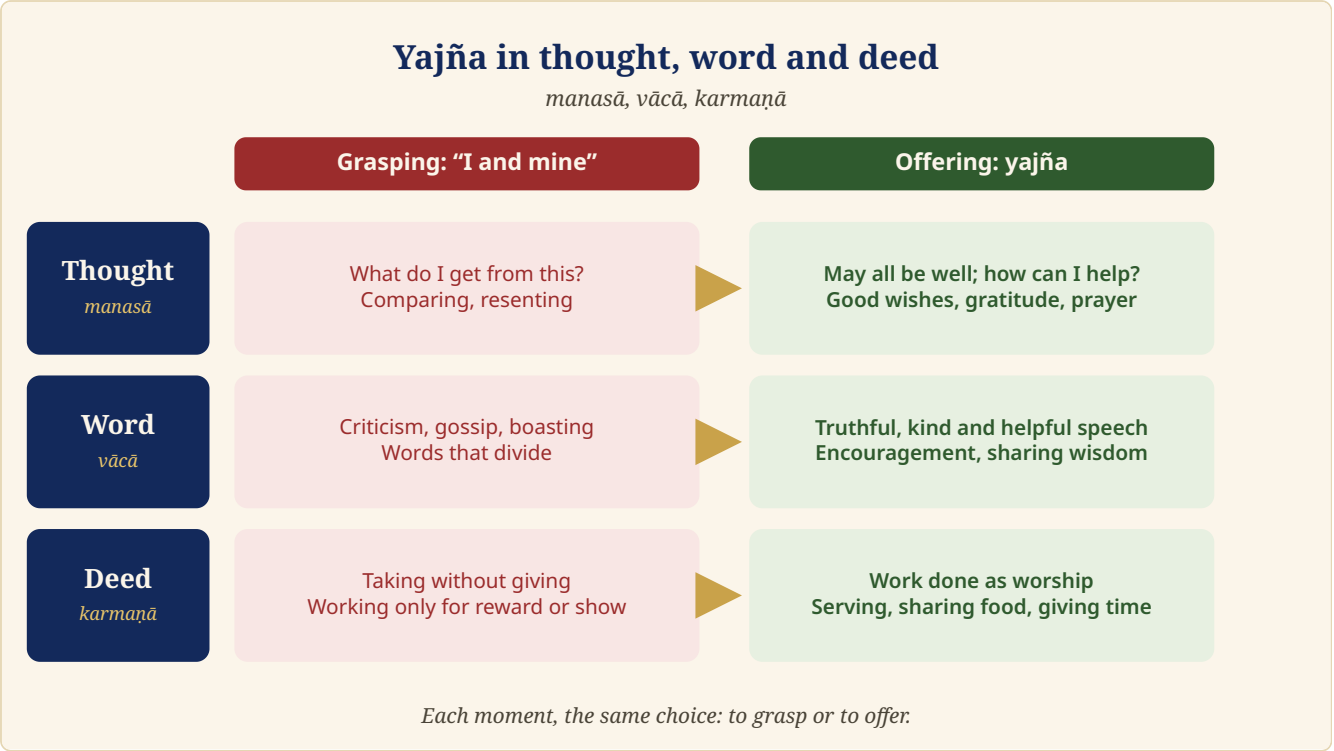
The five daily offerings: each circle widens the self.

REFLECT

- Which of the five daily offerings do I practise now? Which one could I add this month?
- What is my particular gift to offer: time, skill, knowledge, wealth, care or prayer?

7 Yajña in thought, word and deed

Yajña is not only what we do. Our spiritual tradition speaks of purity in three ways: *manasā, vācā, karmaṇā,* in thought, in word and in deed. Each moment offers the same choice: to grasp or to offer.



The same choice in thought, word and deed.

Swami Vivekananda taught that real service needs the whole person in harmony: the **heart** that feels for others, the **head** that understands the real need and plans wisely, and the **hands** that carry it through. Heart alone becomes sentimental; head alone becomes cold; hands alone become tiring. When all three work together as an offering, giving becomes an art.

REFLECT

- In which of the three, thought, word or deed, do I most often grasp rather than offer?
- In my service, which is weakest: heart, head or hands?

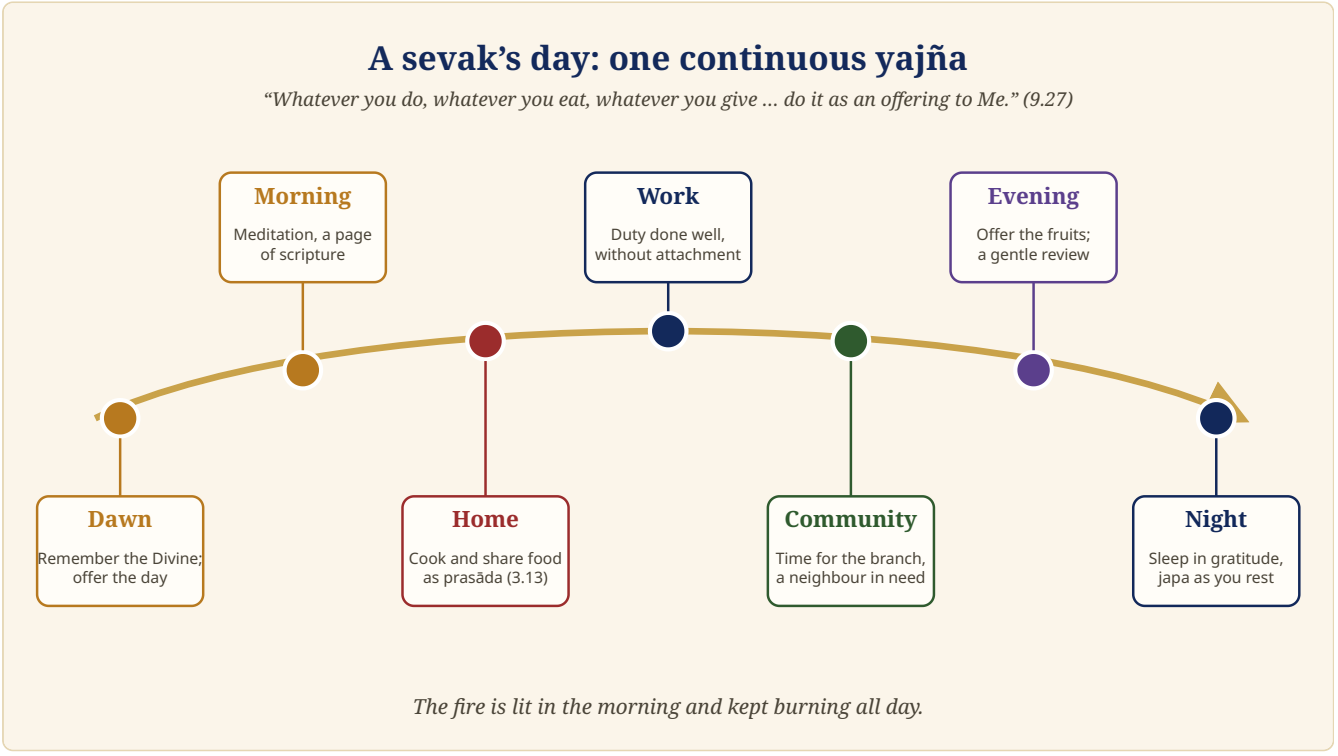
8 A day in the life of a sevak

UNDERSTANDING

Sri Krishna gives the key to a life of seva in one verse:

> यत्करोषि यदश्नासि यज्जुहोषि ददासि यत् ।
> यत्तपस्यसि कौन्तेय तत्कुरुष्व मदर्पणम् ॥
>
> *yat karoṣi yad aśnāsi yaj juhoṣi dadāsi yat,*
> *yat tapasyasi kaunteya tat kuruṣva mad-arpaṇam*
>
> Whatever you do, whatever you eat, whatever you offer in worship, whatever you give, whatever discipline you practise, O son of Kuntī, do it as an offering to Me. (9.27)

A sevak is not only someone who volunteers on weekends. For a sevak, the whole day becomes one continuous yajña. The fire is lit in the morning and kept burning all day. Three ideas make this possible. First, **work as worship**: "yoga is skill in action" (*yogaḥ karmasu kauśalam*, 2.50), so ordinary duty done well and unselfishly is itself an offering. Second, **the family as the first field of seva**: care for children and elders is yajña. Third, **constant remembrance**: among all yajñas, says Sri Krishna, "I am japa", the repetition of the holy name (10.25), which turns every moment into an offering.



A sevak's day as one continuous yajña.

The Gītā also describes the inner qualities that grow in such a person: one who "hates no being, is friendly and compassionate to all, free from 'mine' and from ego, even in pain and pleasure, and forgiving" (12.13). Holy Mother Sri Sarada Devi gave the same teaching in her own simple way: learn to make the whole world your own; no one is a stranger.

APPLICATION

Time	The offering	A simple practice
On waking	Remember the Divine and offer the day	A short prayer: “May all my work today be worship.”
Morning	Fill the cup before pouring it out	Ten to fifteen minutes of meditation or japa; read a few lines of the Gītā, the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna or Swami Vivekananda
At home	The family is the first field of seva	Cook and share food as prasāda (3.13); patience with the children; a call to an elderly parent
At work or study	Duty done well is itself an offering	Work with excellence and honesty, without anxiety about the result (3.9); see the divine in each face
In the community	Regular time for others	Time for your NZICA branch, temple or neighbourhood; elders can mentor the young and share their experience
Through the day	Keep the fire alight	A minute of remembrance now and then: “I am an instrument; this is Your work.” Japa while walking or driving (10.25)
Evening	Offer the fruits	Offer the day’s work, its successes and failures, to the Lord. A gentle review: Where did I serve? Where did “I and mine” creep in?
Night	Rest in gratitude	Thank the Lord for the chances to serve; sleep with the holy name

Begin small. Choose one row from the table and practise it for a week before adding another.

REFLECTION AND SELF-EVALUATION

REFLECT

- Which part of my day is already an offering? Which part is most “for me alone”?
- What one practice from the table will I begin tomorrow?

Self-check: how true is this of me?	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
I begin the day by remembering the Divine and offering the day.			
I treat my daily work as an offering, done with care.			
I give regular time to my branch or community.			
I end the day with a gentle review and an offering of the day.			

Repeat the self-check after thirty days of practice. Growth shows as a move to the right.

9 The quality of our offering

The same act of service can be of three qualities, depending on the spirit in which it is done. The Gītā describes yajña of the three *guṇas* (17.11 to 17.13), and the same applies to every act of seva.

Quality	The Gītā's description	In an association
Sāttvika, pure	Offered without seeking reward, with the mind settled in the thought "this ought to be done" (17.11)	Serving quietly, doing what is needed, glad when others succeed
Rājasika, restless	Offered with an eye on the reward, or for show (17.12)	Serving for a title, a photograph or a seat on the stage; competing with other branches
Tāmasika, dull	Done carelessly, without care for others and without faith (17.13)	Turning up late, doing the minimum, serving with resentment

The Gītā also warns of yajña done "in name only, out of show" by those who are "intoxicated with wealth and pride" (16.17). Ego can creep into the best service. These are gentle checks for ourselves, never for judging others:

- **Wanting credit or thanks:** give quietly; offer the fruit to the Lord.
- **Comparing and competing:** remember we are waves of one ocean; another's success is mine.
- **Controlling others:** listen first; I am an instrument, not the doer.
- **Looking down on those we help:** see the divine in them, and be grateful to them.
- **Resentment and fatigue:** renew in prayer and meditation; serve within your strength.

REFLECT

- Think of one recent act of service. Was it sāttvika, rājasika or tāmasika? What would make it purer?

10 When many minds offer together

UNDERSTANDING

Everything said so far applies to one person. But something greater happens when many minds are aligned in the same spirit of service. The theme mantra of our retreat, the Saṁjñāna Sūkta, the hymn of harmony that closes the Ṛg Veda, describes exactly this. Here is the whole hymn as we chant it, verses 2 to 4:

Ṛg Veda 10.191.2

सं गच्छध्वं सं वदध्वं सं वो मनांसि जानताम् ।
देवा भागं यथा पूर्वे संजानाना उपासते ॥

saṁ gacchadhvaṁ saṁ vadadhvaṁ saṁ vo manāṁsi jānatām,
devā bhāgaṁ yathā pūrve saṁjānānā upāsate

Walk together, speak together, let your minds know one another, just as the devas of old, in harmony with one another, each took up their own share.

Ṛg Veda 10.191.3

समानो मन्त्रः समितिः समानी समानं मनः सह चित्तमेषाम् ।
समानं मन्त्रमभि मन्त्रये वः समानेन वो हविषा जुहोमि ॥

samāno mantraḥ samitiḥ samānī samānaṁ manaḥ saha cittam eṣām,
samānaṁ mantram abhi mantraye vaḥ samānena vo haviṣā juhomi

Common be your counsel, one your assembly, alike your minds, joined your thoughts. I place before you a common purpose, and worship with your common offering.

Ṛg Veda 10.191.4

समानी व आकूतिः समाना हृदयानि वः ।
समानमस्तु वो मनो यथा वः सुसहासति ॥

samānī va ākūtiḥ samānā hṛdayāni vaḥ,
samānam astu vo mano yathā vaḥ susahāsati

One be your intention, united your hearts, one your mind, so that you may live and work happily together.

ॐ शान्तिः शान्तिः शान्तिः ॥

The hymn, word by word

Words	Meaning	For our seva
saṁ gacchadhvam, saṁ vadadhvam	walk together, speak together	Act together and speak with one voice; *saṁ*, together, comes three times in the first line: in action, in words and in minds
saṁ vo manāṁsi jānatām	may your minds know one another	Understand one another before deciding; listen first

devā bhāgaṁ yathā pūrve	as the devas of old each took their share	Unity is not sameness: each person and each branch offers its own gifts
samāno mantraḥ, samitiḥ samānī	common counsel, one assembly	A shared purpose, decided together in meetings
samānaṁ manaḥ saha cittam	alike your minds, joined your thoughts	Thinking and feeling as one team, not rival groups
samānena vo haviṣā juhomi	I worship with your common offering	All our offerings of time, skill and care go into one sacred fire
samānī va ākūtiḥ, samānā hṛdayāni	one your intention, united your hearts	Why we serve is the same for all: the good of many
yathā vaḥ susahāsati	so that you may live well together	Harmony is itself the fruit: a joyful community

"A common offering" is a yajña made by many people with one mind. Each member brings a different offering, as the devas in the first verse each took up their own share. All the offerings go into one sacred fire.



Many offerings, one sacred fire: the collective yajña of an association.

The Buddha sent out his first disciples with the words *bahujana hitāya, bahujana sukhāya*: "for the good of many, for the joy of many". Swami Vivekananda held up this ideal for all who serve. When members and branches serve in this spirit, the association becomes a powerful force for collective good. Outwardly, the community is uplifted. Inwardly, every member who offers is purified, and the inner light shines through.

APPLICATION: WHAT THIS MEANS FOR NZICA

- **One purpose, many offerings.** Each branch has its own gifts and its own community. Like the devas who "each took up their own share" (Ṛg Veda 10.191.2), each offers what it does best to the common purpose.

- **Coordinated, not competing.** Branches share ideas, plan together and celebrate one another's work. Competition is the ego of a group; harmony is its yajña.
- **Membership as a spiritual practice.** Every committee meeting, every event set up and packed away, every phone call to a lonely member, can be an offering. The association becomes a *yajña-śālā*, a place of offering, where we learn to be unselfish and thus grow.
- **Meetings as yajña.** Begin with the Saṁjñāna mantra and a moment of silence to remember the common purpose; listen before deciding (*saṁ vo manāṁsi jānatām*); end by offering the outcome.
- **Serving the next generation.** Our young people and our elders need us. A community that serves in the spirit of yajña offers them belonging, meaning and calm.

REFLECTION AND SELF-EVALUATION

REFLECT

- What is my branch's particular "share" to offer to the whole of NZICA?
- Where do I notice competition rather than harmony, and how could I help to change it?

Self-check: how true is this of me?	Rarely	Sometimes	Often
I see my NZICA membership as a way to serve and to grow.			
I listen to others and seek a common view before decisions.			
I am glad when another member or branch succeeds.			
I offer my particular gifts to our shared purpose, without needing credit.			

Repeat the self-check after thirty days of practice. Growth shows as a move to the right.

11 From reflection to practice

Manana leads to nididhyāsana: what we have understood must be lived. Here are some simple practices to choose from.

For each person: thirty days of yajña

1. **Morning offering.** On waking, offer the day: “May all my work today be worship.”
2. **Offer before eating.** Chant 4.24, or simply remember the Lord, before each meal.
3. **One act of seva a day**, done quietly, expecting nothing.
4. **One kind word a day** to someone who needs it.
5. **Evening review.** Where did I serve? Where did “I and mine” creep in? Did I give more than I received?

For each branch

- Begin meetings with the Saṁjñāna mantra, and a moment of silence to remember the common purpose.
- Choose one seva project for the year that serves those most in need: elders, newcomers or young people.
- Share what is learned with other branches, and support one another’s events.
- After each event, ask together: what went well, what could be better, and did we serve with joy?

Your thirty-day self-check card

Copy the twenty statements from the self-checks in Sections 3, 4, 5, 8 and 10 into a notebook, or print those pages. Mark each one today, then practise the five daily steps above for thirty days and mark them again. Look for the statements that have moved towards “often”, and give thanks; choose one that has not moved and make it your focus for the next month. In Swami Ranganathananda’s words, this is how we can know whether we are growing spiritually.

The seva tree note you wrote at the retreat can be your starting point. Keep it where you will see it each morning.

A The teaching at a glance

Teaching	Verses	In everyday life
Life is a cycle of giving and receiving	3.10 to 3.16	We live on what nature, parents, teachers and society give us; giving back is not charity but our share in turning the wheel
Do not take without giving	3.12	Using the earth's resources, our community's support or our family's care without giving anything back makes us a "thief"
Eat what remains after offering	3.13, 4.31	Offer food before eating; cook for others, share a meal; enjoy what remains as prasāda
Work done as an offering frees	3.9, 4.23	Do the day's work as worship, without anxiety for results
See Brahman in every part of the act	4.24	The one who serves, the service and the one served are one Reality, like waves of one ocean
Many forms of yajña	4.25 to 4.30	Giving money, self-discipline, study, breathing practice and sense control are all offerings
Knowledge is the highest offering	4.33, 18.70	Sharing wisdom, teaching, and studying the Gītā together is itself yajña
Offer everything to the Lord	9.27	Whatever you do, eat or give: begin and end the day with an offering
The simplest yajña is japa	10.25	Repeating the holy name is a yajña anyone can do, anywhere
The spirit decides the quality	17.11 to 17.13	Serving because it ought to be done (sāttvika), rather than for show or reward (rājasika)
Never give up yajña	18.5	Keep regular giving, service and discipline in life; they purify even the wise
Many minds, one offering	Ṛg Veda 10.191.3	Members and branches aligned in one purpose, for the good of many and the joy of many

B The Gītā verses on yajña

The verses of the Bhagavad Gītā drawn on in this study, in Gītā order: Devanagari, transliteration and a plain English rendering. A few verses where the word yajña does not appear (3.11, 3.16, 4.24, 4.26, 4.27, 4.29, 9.27) are included because the teaching on yajña runs through them.

The wheel of yajña (Chapter 3)

3.9

यज्ञार्थात्कर्मणोऽन्यत्र लोकोऽयं कर्मबन्धनः ।
तदर्थं कर्म कौन्तेय मुक्तसङ्गः समाचर ॥

yajñārthāt karmaṇo 'nyatra loko 'yaṁ karma-bandhanaḥ,
tad-arthaṁ karma kaunteya mukta-saṅgaḥ samācara

This world is bound by work, except work done as yajña. So, O son of Kuntī, do your work for that purpose, free from attachment.

3.10

सहयज्ञाः प्रजाः सृष्ट्वा पुरोवाच प्रजापतिः ।
अनेन प्रसविष्यध्वमेष वोऽस्त्विष्टकामधुक् ॥

saha-yajñāḥ prajāḥ sṛṣṭvā purovāca prajāpatiḥ,
anena prasaviṣyadhvam eṣa vo 'stv iṣṭa-kāma-dhuk

In the beginning the Creator brought forth beings together with yajña and said: "By this you shall prosper; let this be the wish-fulfilling cow that gives you what you need."

3.11

देवान्भावयतानेन ते देवा भावयन्तु वः ।
परस्परं भावयन्तः श्रेयः परमवाप्स्यथ ॥

devān bhāvayatānena te devā bhāvayantu vaḥ,
parasparaṁ bhāvayantaḥ śreyaḥ param avāpsyatha

Nourish the devas with this, and may the devas nourish you. Nourishing one another, you will attain the highest good.

3.12

इष्टान्भोगान्हि वो देवा दास्यन्ते यज्ञभाविताः ।
तैर्दत्तानप्रदायैभ्यो यो भुङ्क्ते स्तेन एव सः ॥

iṣṭān bhogān hi vo devā dāsyante yajña-bhāvitāḥ,
tair dattān apradāyaibhyo yo bhuṅkte stena eva saḥ

Nourished by yajña, the devas will give you the good things you desire. One who enjoys what they give without offering anything in return is nothing but a thief.

3.13

यज्ञशिष्टाशिनः सन्तो मुच्यन्ते सर्वकिल्बिषैः ।
भुञ्जते ते त्वघं पापा ये पचन्त्यात्मकारणात् ॥

yajña-śiṣṭāśinaḥ santo mucyante sarva-kilbiṣaiḥ,
bhuñjate te tv aghaṁ pāpā ye pacanty ātma-kāraṇāt

The good who eat what remains after yajña are freed from all faults. But those who cook only for themselves eat sin.

3.14

अन्नाद्भवन्ति भूतानि पर्जन्यादन्नसम्भवः ।
यज्ञाद्भवति पर्जन्यो यज्ञः कर्मसमुद्भवः ॥

annād bhavanti bhūtāni parjanyād anna-sambhavaḥ,
yajñād bhavati parjanyo yajñaḥ karma-samudbhavaḥ

Beings live on food; food comes from rain; rain comes from yajña; and yajña is born of action.

3.15

कर्म ब्रह्मोद्भवं विद्धि ब्रह्माक्षरसमुद्भवम् ।
तस्मात्सर्वगतं ब्रह्म नित्यं यज्ञे प्रतिष्ठितम् ॥

karma brahmodbhavaṁ viddhi brahmākṣara-samudbhavam,
tasmāt sarva-gataṁ brahma nityaṁ yajñe pratiṣṭhitam

Know that action arises from the Veda, and the Veda from the Imperishable. Therefore the all-pervading Brahman is ever present in yajña.

3.16

एवं प्रवर्तितं चक्रं नानुवर्तयतीह यः ।
अघायुरिन्द्रियारामो मोघं पार्थ स जीवति ॥

evaṁ pravartitaṁ cakraṁ nānuvartayatīha yaḥ,
aghāyur indriyārāmo moghaṁ pārtha sa jīvati

One who does not help turn the wheel set in motion in this way, living only for the pleasure of the senses, lives in vain, O Pārtha.

The many kinds of yajña (Chapter 4)

4.23

गतसङ्गस्य मुक्तस्य ज्ञानावस्थितचेतसः ।
यज्ञायाचरतः कर्म समग्रं प्रविलीयते ॥

gata-saṅgasya muktasya jñānāvasthita-cetasaḥ,
yajñāyācarataḥ karma samagraṁ pravilīyate

For one who is free from attachment, liberated, with the mind established in knowledge, and who works for the sake of yajña, all action melts away completely.

4.24

ब्रह्मार्पणं ब्रह्महविर्ब्रह्माग्नौ ब्रह्मणा हुतम् ।
ब्रह्मैव तेन गन्तव्यं ब्रह्मकर्मसमाधिना ॥

brahmārpaṇaṁ brahma havir brahmāgnau brahmaṇā hutam,
brahmaiva tena gantavyaṁ brahma-karma-samādhinā

The act of offering is Brahman, the offering is Brahman, it is offered by Brahman into the fire that is Brahman. One who sees Brahman in every action reaches Brahman alone.

4.25

दैवमेवापरे यज्ञं योगिनः पर्युपासते ।
ब्रह्माग्नावपरे यज्ञं यज्ञेनैवोपजुह्वति ॥

daivam evāpare yajñaṁ yoginaḥ paryupāsate,
brahmāgnāv apare yajñaṁ yajñenaivopajuhvati

Some yogīs perform yajña as worship of the devas. Others offer the self as an offering into the fire of Brahman.

4.26

श्रोत्रादीनीन्द्रियाण्यन्ये संयमाग्निषु जुह्वति ।
शब्दादीन्विषयानन्य इन्द्रियाग्निषु जुह्वति ॥

śrotrādīnīndriyāṇy anye saṁyamāgniṣu juhvati,
śabdādīn viṣayān anya indriyāgniṣu juhvati

Some offer hearing and the other senses into the fires of self-control. Others offer sound and the other objects of the senses into the fires of the senses.

4.27

सर्वाणीन्द्रियकर्माणि प्राणकर्माणि चापरे ।
आत्मसंयमयोगाग्नौ जुह्वति ज्ञानदीपिते ॥

sarvāṇīndriya-karmāṇi prāṇa-karmāṇi cāpare,
ātma-saṁyama-yogāgnau juhvati jñāna-dīpite

Others offer all the activities of the senses and of the life-breath into the fire of self-mastery, kindled by knowledge.

4.28

द्रव्ययज्ञास्तपोयज्ञा योगयज्ञास्तथापरे ।
स्वाध्यायज्ञानयज्ञाश्च यतयः संशितव्रताः ॥

dravya-yajñās tapo-yajñā yoga-yajñās tathāpare,
svādhyāya-jñāna-yajñāś ca yatayaḥ saṁśita-vratāḥ

Some offer their wealth as yajña, some their austerity, some their practice of yoga; and others, striving and firm in their vows, offer study of scripture and knowledge.

4.29

अपाने जुह्वति प्राणं प्राणेऽपानं तथाऽपरे ।
प्राणापानगती रुद्ध्वा प्राणायामपरायणाः ॥

apāne juhvati prāṇaṁ prāṇe 'pānaṁ tathāpare,
prāṇāpāna-gatī ruddhvā prāṇāyāma-parāyaṇāḥ

Others, devoted to the control of breath (prāṇāyāma), offer the in-breath into the out-breath and the out-breath into the in-breath, restraining the flow of both.

4.30

अपरे नियताहाराः प्राणान्प्राणेषु जुह्वति ।
सर्वेऽप्येते यज्ञविदो यज्ञक्षपितकल्मषाः ॥

apare niyatāhārāḥ prāṇān prāṇeṣu juhvati,
sarve 'py ete yajña-vido yajña-kṣapita-kalmaṣāḥ

Others, moderate in food, offer the life-breaths into the life-breaths. All of these know yajña, and through yajña their impurities are destroyed.

4.31

यज्ञशिष्टामृतभुजो यान्ति ब्रह्म सनातनम् ।
नायं लोकोऽस्त्ययज्ञस्य कुतोऽन्यः कुरुसत्तम ॥

yajña-śiṣṭāmṛta-bhujo yānti brahma sanātanam,
nāyaṁ loko 'sty ayajñasya kuto 'nyaḥ kuru-sattama

Those who partake of the nectar that remains after yajña reach the eternal Brahman. Even this world is not for one who offers no yajña; how then the next, O best of the Kurus?

4.32

एवं बहुविधा यज्ञा वितता ब्रह्मणो मुखे ।
कर्मजान्विद्धि तान्सर्वानेवं ज्ञात्वा विमोक्ष्यसे ॥

evaṁ bahu-vidhā yajñā vitatā brahmaṇo mukhe,
karma-jān viddhi tān sarvān evaṁ jñātvā vimokṣyase

Many kinds of yajña are thus set out in the Veda. Know them all to be born of action; knowing this, you will be free.

4.33

श्रेयान्द्रव्यमयाद्यज्ञाज्ज्ञानयज्ञः परन्तप ।
सर्वं कर्माखिलं पार्थ ज्ञाने परिसमाप्यते ॥

śreyān dravya-mayād yajñāj jñāna-yajñaḥ parantapa,
sarvaṁ karmākhilaṁ pārtha jñāne parisamāpyate

The yajña of knowledge is higher than any yajña of material things, O scorcher of foes. All action, without exception, finds its fulfilment in knowledge, O Pārtha.

The Lord in yajña (Chapters 5 to 10)

5.29

भोक्तारं यज्ञतपसां सर्वलोकमहेश्वरम् ।
सुहृदं सर्वभूतानां ज्ञात्वा मां शान्तिमृच्छति ॥

bhoktāraṁ yajña-tapasāṁ sarva-loka-maheśvaram,
suhṛdaṁ sarva-bhūtānāṁ jñātvā māṁ śāntim ṛcchati

Knowing Me as the enjoyer of all yajña and austerity, the great Lord of all the worlds, and the friend of all beings, one attains peace.

7.30

साधिभूताधिदैवं मां साधियज्ञं च ये विदुः ।
प्रयाणकालेऽपि च मां ते विदुर्युक्तचेतसः ॥

sādhibhūtādhidaivaṁ māṁ sādhiyajñaṁ ca ye viduḥ,
prayāṇa-kāle 'pi ca māṁ te vidur yukta-cetasaḥ

Those who know Me as the reality behind matter, behind the divine powers and behind all yajña, with their minds united with Me, know Me even at the time of death.

8.2

अधियज्ञः कथं कोऽत्र देहेऽस्मिन्मधुसूदन ।
प्रयाणकाले च कथं ज्ञेयोऽसि नियतात्मभिः ॥

adhiyajñaḥ kathaṁ ko 'tra dehe 'smin madhusūdana,
prayāṇa-kāle ca kathaṁ jñeyo 'si niyatātmabhiḥ

Arjuna asks: Who is the adhiyajña, the Lord of yajña, here in this body, and how does He dwell in it, O Madhusūdana? And how are You to be known at the time of death by those who are self-controlled?

8.4

अधिभूतं क्षरो भावः पुरुषश्चाधिदैवतम् ।
अधियज्ञोऽहमेवात्र देहे देहभृतां वर ॥

adhibhūtaṁ kṣaro bhāvaḥ puruṣaś cādhidaivatam,
adhiyajño 'ham evātra dehe deha-bhṛtāṁ vara

The perishable is the basis of the material world; the cosmic Person is the basis of the divine powers; and I Myself, here in the body, am the adhiyajña, the Lord of all yajña, O best of the embodied.

9.15

ज्ञानयज्ञेन चाप्यन्ये यजन्तो मामुपासते ।
एकत्वेन पृथक्त्वेन बहुधा विश्वतोमुखम् ॥

jñāna-yajñena cāpy anye yajanto mām upāsate,
ekatvena pṛthaktvena bahudhā viśvato-mukham

Others worship Me through the yajña of knowledge: some as the One, some as distinct from themselves, and some in many ways, as the One whose face is everywhere.

9.16

अहं क्रतुरहं यज्ञः स्वधाऽहमहमौषधम् ।
मन्त्रोऽहमहमेवाज्यमहमग्निरहं हुतम् ॥

ahaṁ kratur ahaṁ yajñaḥ svadhāham aham auṣadham,
mantro 'ham aham evājyam aham agnir ahaṁ hutam

I am the ritual, I am the yajña, I am the offering to the ancestors, I am the healing herb. I am the mantra, I am the ghee, I am the fire, and I am the act of offering.

9.24

अहं हि सर्वयज्ञानां भोक्ता च प्रभुरेव च ।
न तु मामभिजानन्ति तत्त्वेनातश्च्यवन्ति ते ॥

ahaṁ hi sarva-yajñānāṁ bhoktā ca prabhur eva ca,
na tu mām abhijānanti tattvenātaś cyavanti te

I alone am the enjoyer and the Lord of all yajñas. Those who do not know Me in truth fall back again.

9.27

यत्करोषि यदश्नासि यज्जुहोषि ददासि यत् ।
यत्तपस्यसि कौन्तेय तत्कुरुष्व मदर्पणम् ॥

yat karoṣi yad aśnāsi yaj juhoṣi dadāsi yat,
yat tapasyasi kaunteya tat kuruṣva mad-arpaṇam

Whatever you do, whatever you eat, whatever you offer in worship, whatever you give, whatever discipline you practise, O son of Kuntī, do it as an offering to Me.

10.25

महर्षीणां भृगुरहं गिरामस्म्येकमक्षरम् ।
यज्ञानां जपयज्ञोऽस्मि स्थावराणां हिमालयः ॥

maharṣīṇāṁ bhṛgur ahaṁ girām asmy ekam akṣaram,
yajñānāṁ japa-yajño 'smi sthāvarāṇāṁ himālayaḥ

Among the great sages I am Bhṛgu; among words I am the one syllable Om; among yajñas I am japa, the repetition of the holy name; among things that do not move I am the Himālaya.

The quality of yajña (Chapters 16 to 18)

16.1

अभयं सत्त्वसंशुद्धिः ज्ञानयोगव्यवस्थितिः ।
दानं दमश्च यज्ञश्च स्वाध्यायस्तप आर्जवम् ॥

abhayaṁ sattva-saṁśuddhir jñāna-yoga-vyavasthitiḥ,
dānaṁ damaś ca yajñaś ca svādhyāyas tapa ārjavam

Fearlessness, purity of heart, steadfastness in knowledge and yoga, generosity, self-control, yajña, study of scripture, austerity and straightforwardness (the first of the divine qualities).

16.17

आत्मसम्भाविताः स्तब्धा धनमानमदान्विताः ।
यजन्ते नामयज्ञैस्ते दम्भेनाविधिपूर्वकम् ॥

ātma-sambhāvitāḥ stabdhā dhana-māna-madānvitāḥ,
yajante nāma-yajñais te dambhenāvidhi-pūrvakam

Self-important, stubborn, intoxicated with wealth and pride, they perform yajñas in name only, out of show and without regard for the proper way.

17.7

आहारस्त्वपि सर्वस्य त्रिविधो भवति प्रियः ।
यज्ञस्तपस्तथा दानं तेषां भेदमिमं शृणु ॥

āhāras tv api sarvasya tri-vidho bhavati priyaḥ,
yajñas tapas tathā dānaṁ teṣāṁ bhedam imaṁ śṛṇu

Even the food each person likes is of three kinds; so too are yajña, austerity and giving. Hear how they differ.

17.11

अफलाकाङ्क्षिभिर्यज्ञो विधिदृष्टो य इज्यते ।
यष्टव्यमेवेति मनः समाधाय स सात्त्विकः ॥

aphalākāṅkṣibhir yajño vidhi-dṛṣṭo ya ijyate,
yaṣṭavyam eveti manaḥ samādhāya sa sāttvikaḥ

The yajña offered in the proper way by those who seek no reward, with the mind settled in the thought "this ought to be offered", is sāttvika, pure.

17.12

अभिसंधाय तु फलं दम्भार्थमपि चैव यत् ।
इज्यते भरतश्रेष्ठ तं यज्ञं विद्धि राजसम् ॥

abhisandhāya tu phalaṁ dambhārtham api caiva yat,
ijyate bharata-śreṣṭha taṁ yajñaṁ viddhi rājasam

But the yajña offered with an eye on the reward, or for show, know that to be rājasika, O best of the Bharatas.

17.13

विधिहीनमसृष्टान्नं मन्त्रहीनमदक्षिणम् ।
श्रद्धाविरहितं यज्ञं तामसं परिचक्षते ॥

vidhi-hīnam asṛṣṭānnaṁ mantra-hīnam adakṣiṇam,
śraddhā-virahitaṁ yajñaṁ tāmasaṁ paricakṣate

The yajña done without the proper way, without sharing food, without mantra, without gifts to the priests and without faith is called tāmasika.

17.24

तस्मादोमित्युदाहृत्य यज्ञदानतपःक्रियाः ।
प्रवर्तन्ते विधानोक्ताः सततं ब्रह्मवादिनाम् ॥

tasmād om ity udāhṛtya yajña-dāna-tapaḥ-kriyāḥ,
pravartante vidhānoktāḥ satataṁ brahma-vādinām

Therefore those devoted to Brahman always begin their acts of yajña, giving and austerity with the word Om.

17.25

तदित्यनभिसन्धाय फलं यज्ञतपःक्रियाः ।
दानक्रियाश्च विविधाः क्रियन्ते मोक्षकाङ्क्षिभिः ॥

tad ity anabhisandhāya phalaṁ yajña-tapaḥ-kriyāḥ,
dāna-kriyāś ca vividhāḥ kriyante mokṣa-kāṅkṣibhiḥ

With the word Tat, and without seeking any reward, those who long for liberation perform the many acts of yajña, austerity and giving.

17.27

यज्ञे तपसि दाने च स्थितिः सदिति चोच्यते ।
कर्म चैव तदर्थीयं सदित्येवाभिधीयते ॥

yajñe tapasi dāne ca sthitiḥ sad iti cocyate,
karma caiva tad-arthīyaṁ sad ity evābhidhīyate

Steadfastness in yajña, austerity and giving is called Sat; and any action done for the sake of the Divine is also called Sat.

18.5

यज्ञदानतपःकर्म न त्याज्यं कार्यमेव तत् ।
यज्ञो दानं तपश्चैव पावनानि मनीषिणाम् ॥

yajña-dāna-tapaḥ-karma na tyājyaṁ kāryam eva tat,
yajño dānaṁ tapaś caiva pāvanāni manīṣiṇām

Acts of yajña, giving and austerity are not to be given up; they must be done. Yajña, giving and austerity purify even the wise.

18.70

अध्येष्यते च य इमं धर्म्यं संवादमावयोः ।
ज्ञानयज्ञेन तेनाहमिष्टः स्यामिति मे मतिः ॥

adhyeṣyate ca ya imaṁ dharmyaṁ saṁvādam āvayoḥ,
jñāna-yajñena tenāham iṣṭaḥ syām iti me matiḥ

One who studies this sacred dialogue of ours will have worshipped Me through the yajña of knowledge: such is My conviction.